Lecture 15: A Person in the World of People: Morality

Introduction to Psychology · Yale University, Spring 2007 · Professor Paul Bloom

Study guide based on the lecture transcript. Source: https://oyc.yale.edu/psychology/psyc-110/lecture-15 (CC BY-NC-SA 3.0).

Before you start

This lecture is about the psychology of morality. Professor Bloom looks at three parts of morality: moral feelings, moral judgments and moral action. He asks where moral feelings come from, how we judge right and wrong, and why good people sometimes do bad things.

Learning goals

After this lecture you should be able to:

- Explain two evolutionary reasons for moral feelings: kin selection and cooperation.
- Describe the Robber's Cave and minimal group studies and what they show about groups.
- Compare Shweder's three ethics and explain Haidt's idea of "moral dumbfounding".
- Describe the factors that made people more or less obedient in Milgram's studies.
- Give an example of the two forces for evil and the two forces for good.

Key ideas

1. Introduction

Professor Bloom reviews the course so far, from the brain to sex and food. Later lectures cover social thought, some "mysteries" (sleep, laughter and religion), mental illness and happiness.

2. Kin Selection, Cooperation and Moral Feelings

- Moral feelings include shame, pride, righteous anger, and also affection and caring. Evolution explains them in two ways. **Kin selection:** animals can be altruistic (helpful at a cost to themselves) toward relatives who share their genes. **Cooperation:** even unrelated animals give warning cries, groom each other and share food, and this gives emotions such as guilt and anger.
- **Empathy** is "the feeling that your pain matters to me." Babies cry more at recordings of other babies crying than at recordings of their own crying. In studies that would be unethical today, a chimpanzee went a long time without food rather than press a lever that shocked another, unrelated chimpanzee. But when a rabbit was in the other room, it pressed the lever again and again.
- People with more empathy tend to be nicer. There is some reason to believe that in psychopaths this empathy is broken.
- **The Robber's Cave study:** Sherif put 11- and 12-year-old boys at a camp into two groups, "The Eagles" and "The Rattlers". Competition led to negative stereotypes and violence. Peace talks,

shared meals and sermons on brotherly love failed. What worked was a **superordinate goal**: all the boys were told the water line was cut, so they had to defend the camp together.

- **Minimal groups:** Tajfel showed that you do not need much to make a group. People randomly called "Klee lovers" or "Kandinsky lovers", or divided by a coin flip, favored their own group. So who matters to us depends partly on our groups.

3. Moral Reasoning and Moral Judgments

- A **moral judgment** says something is good or bad, fair or unfair. Disliking strawberry ice cream is not one, because it carries no obligation and no sanctions (punishment). "No killing babies" is a moral judgment.
- Moral questions are everyday questions: what to eat, giving to charity, how to treat homeless people.
- Some intuitions seem universal, such as anger at cheaters and gratitude toward sharers. But cultures also differ. The anthropologist **Richard Shweder** describes three ethics: **autonomy** (rights, equality, freedom), **community** (duty, status, hierarchy, interdependence) and **divinity** (purity, sanctity, pollution, sin). Western debates are usually framed in terms of autonomy.
- **Jonathan Haidt** told stories where nobody is harmed. Julie and Mark, a brother and sister, make love once, using birth control, and keep it secret. Most people say it is wrong but struggle to explain why. Haidt calls this **moral dumbfounding**. When their reasons are taken away, the feeling of "wrong" stays. Our moral judgments can be guided by factors we are not conscious of.

4. Milgram's Work in the Context of Morality

- Milgram, a Yale professor, was motivated by the Holocaust. The subject thought he was teaching someone in a memory game. The "learner" was really a **confederate** (someone working with the experimenter). The majority of people gave what they believed were fatal shocks.
- The subjects were not unusual psychopaths, and they were not sadistic: nobody enjoyed giving the shocks.
- Fewer people went all the way when the study was moved away from Yale, when the learner was next to them, when orders came by phone, when another person rebelled, or when they chose their own shock level.
- Critiques: the study is why we have **human-subjects committees**. Only 2% said they were sorry they took part, but people left believing they would kill someone if told to. Some argue (this is controversial) that obedience is not a good model for genocide: Goldhagen said many people in the Holocaust were enthusiastic volunteers.
- The "perfect situation" for making someone do a terrible thing: authority, a self-assured experimenter who takes responsibility, distance from the victim, and a new situation with no model of how to behave.

5. Two Forces for Evil, Two Forces for Good

- **Evil 1: deindividuation of self.** In a group, responsibility becomes diffuse (spread out). Orders and anonymity (masks) also reduce it. This explains why bystanders often do not help, as in the Kitty Genovese case. Advice: point to one person: "You in the green sweater, call the police."

- **Evil 2: denigration of others.** We make people matter less through distance, words ("cargo"), humor, taking away names, and **disgust**. Genocidal movements have used disgust to dehumanize people (treat them as less than human).
- **Good 1: contact and interdependence.** Robert Wright: "One of the many reasons I don't want to bomb the Japanese is that they built my minivan." **The Contact Hypothesis:** contact makes groups like each other more, especially with equal status, a common goal and social support, as in the U.S. military.
- **Good 2: perspective taking.** JFK asked white listeners to imagine standing in the place of an American with dark skin. Stories and metaphors ("my brothers and my sisters") also expand moral concern.

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning in simple English	Example from the lecture
kin selection	evolution favors helping relatives who share your genes	generosity towards kin
empathy	feeling that another person's pain matters to you	babies upset by other babies' crying
psychopath	a person whose instinctive empathy seems broken	"What do I care? I'm not her"
superordinate goal	a goal that all groups share	defending the camp together
minimal groups	groups made from tiny or random differences	Klee lovers and Kandinsky lovers
moral judgment	a judgment of right or wrong, with obligation and punishment	"no killing babies"
ethics of autonomy	morality based on rights, equality and freedom	Western debates about abortion
moral dumbfounding	feeling something is wrong but not being able to explain why	the Julie and Mark story
confederate	a person who secretly works with the experimenter	the "learner" in Milgram's study
deindividuation	losing the sense of yourself as a responsible individual	smashing windows with twenty people
diffusion of responsibility	in a group, each person feels less responsible	the Kitty Genovese case
Contact Hypothesis	contact between groups increases liking	the U.S. military
perspective taking	seeing a situation from another person's point of view	JFK's plea for equal rights

Check your understanding

1. What are the two evolutionary explanations for moral feelings?
2. How do we know babies are not just confusing other babies' crying with their own?
3. In the Robber's Cave study, what failed and what worked?
4. Why is "I don't like strawberry ice cream" not a moral judgment?
5. Compare Shweder's three ethics.
6. What is moral dumbfounding? Give an example.
7. Name three changes that made people less obedient in Milgram's studies.
8. A man falls on a busy street and shouts "Help!", but nobody stops. Why? What should he do?

Answer guide

1. Kin selection (helping relatives who share our genes) and cooperation (our minds evolved to cooperate with unrelated others and to deal with cheating).
2. Babies cried more at recordings of other babies crying than at recordings of their own crying.
3. Peace talks, shared meals and sermons failed. A superordinate goal worked: defending the camp when the water line was cut.
4. It carries no obligation and no sanctions. Nobody must avoid it, and nobody should be punished for eating it.
5. Autonomy is about rights and freedom; community is about duty and hierarchy; divinity is about purity and sin.
6. Feeling an act is wrong without a good reason. Most people say Julie and Mark were wrong, but end with "it's just wrong."
7. Any three: away from Yale; learner next to them; orders by phone; another person rebelling; choosing your own shock level.
8. Diffusion of responsibility: each person thinks someone else will help. He should point to one person and give a clear request.

English practice

Useful phrases from the lecture

- "The question is, ..." - introduces the main problem. Example: "The question is, 'How could moral feelings evolve?'"
- "..., suggesting that ..." - links a result to its meaning. Example: "... suggesting that their response is to some extent a response to the 'otherness'."
- "What's particularly interesting is ..." - points to the most surprising part of a finding.
- "On the other hand, ..." - introduces a contrasting case.
- "This is controversial." - warns that experts disagree.

Speaking task (with your AI tutor)

- Explain the Robber's Cave study in 4-6 sentences. Use "in-group", "superordinate goal" and "common enemy".

Writing task

- Write one paragraph (80-120 words): What is the "perfect situation" for getting someone to do a terrible thing? Use Milgram's study as your example.

Study with your tutor

Things to say to your tutor in Live conversation:

- "Let's review Lecture 15. Ask me questions about the Robber's Cave study and minimal groups, one at a time."
- "Quiz me on the key vocabulary of Lecture 15."
- "I will explain Shweder's three ethics and moral dumbfounding in my own words. Check my understanding and my English."
- "Ask me which factors made obedience go up or down in Milgram's studies."

Readings from the original course

- Gray, Peter. Psychology (5th edition), chapter 14
- Cialdini, Robert B. "Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion." In The Norton Psychology Reader. Edited by Gary Marcus. New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2006. pp. 265-272

My notes